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Google Formally Accused of Antitrust Violations by EU



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer
May 20, 2015

In a formal complaint known as a Statement of Objections, the European Union now accuses Google of Antitrust violations. This comes after a [five year European investigation](#) of the search giant. The complaint is based on Google's accused exploitation of its search dominance.

Married with this complaint is news of a new investigation the EU opened on Google's OS platform, Android. The EU asserts that while the operating system is open-source it has multiple proprietary components that prevent true competition.

"There's a level of animosity in Europe against U.S. tech companies," said Serafino Abate, director of a Brussels-based research organization. This makes sense considering the overwhelming rush of technological advancements coming out of Silicon Valley in the past few years. It may make European countries feel unable to compete in walled garden tech ecosystems, like search engines or cell phone operating systems.

US Government's Take

The Federal Trade Commission took up the charge of investigating Google in 2012, after reports of the company favoring the search engine's own services over that of Amazon, Yelp, and others. Perhaps the most

seemingly nefarious instance is when Google purchased smart-home product company Nest, and shortly thereafter [tanked the rankings](#) of Nest's competitors in Google's search results.

Similar claims emerged of Google's tinkering with its search algorithm which decreased the ranking of eBay search results around the same time Google began [ramping up its own](#) ecommerce efforts.

The FTC reviewed each complaint and found no fault on Google's part. The US regulatory commission "recommended against an antitrust suit because Google had adequate [pro-consumer justifications](#) for its actions," reports Wired. This justification may not be enough to prevent the EU from delivering the search giant some harsh penalties for the new round of accused violations.



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Moving Forward

Google has yet to publicly respond to the EU accusations of antitrust violations. But, it apparently knew of the news before it broke as it alerted its "employees [not to comment](#) on the matter either internally or externally."

"We have a very strong case, with especially good arguments when it comes to better services for users and

increased competition," reads the [leaked internal memo](#) Google sent to employees.

And it's hard to argue against the fact that Google makes searching for information easier than any of its competitors. A visitor can receive answers to simple questions like "What is the weather like?" or "What is three dollars in British pounds?" Google continues to streamline product searches, offering reviews and competitive prices from multiple vendors. "Google holds a roughly 90 percent share in the [European] region's search market, and the company contends that in both web searches and Android software [it plays fair](#)," reports the New York Times.

But the main concern for those who accuse Google of antitrust violations is that Google is far more than a search engine. Google is an ad network, Google is a technology hardware company, Google is dipping its toe in the waters of tangible products which may run the risk of squelching competition through its closed search system.

Takeaway

The days of "don't be evil" as Google's corporate mantra are long gone. Search is not benign, not while there's money to be made, and not while the value of ranking first in search results is worth a princely sum.

Google is synonymous with search, so much that it's become a verb for the very process of searching for information on the net.

But, it appears Google wants to be more than a just search service. It buys companies and releases its own products. It would seem this is a conflict of interest that its products could be promoted with greater visibility than its competitors on a platform once considered neutral.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He

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